

*The
Enchantingly
Easy*

Persian Cookbook

Recipes inspire by Home



Parisa Khayami



About Iranian food

A visit to Iran yields a stunning variety of culinary delights. Between the familiar kebab and stews, there's a vast spectrum of foods: caviar, pickle, and smoked fish in the north; samosas, falafel and hot and sour shrimp in the south; noodles, flatbread and rosewater-scented ice cream across the country. Take a look at Iran's place on the map and it's easy to understand why the scope of native foods is so wide. Once the center of the Persian Empire, Iran neighbours the former Soviet Union countries, as well as Afghanistan, Pakistan, the Arab states and Turkey. Many coveted ingredients are native to Iran, including pistachios, almonds, walnuts, saffron, oranges, pomegranates and grapes. Iran has a variable climate with four distinct seasons, and unlike other parts of the Middle East, where the dry terrain limited what food could be grown.

Contents

Appetizer: Kuku Sabzi
1



Baked Rice: Tahchin
3



Herb Stew: Ghormeh sabzi
5



Dessert: Faloodeh
7



Nooshe jan!

(Yes, that's Farsi for "bon appétit.")



Kuku is a Persian dish that usually involves eggs beaten with a variety of ingredients. What distinguishes kuku from an omelet or a frittata, however, is just how little egg is actually in the dish; the egg is simply used to bind the other ingredients together, not stand on its own.

Some kukus are savoury, filled with fried potato or zucchini; some are sweet, often studded with quince, dates and pistachios. However, the most popular variety is the kuku sabzi, which is typically served during the Persian New Year (Nowruz) and can be eaten warm, cold or at room temperature. The eggs are filled with a heaping mound of fresh herbs, but it's the tablespoon of dried fenugreek that makes the dish so fragrant and aromatic.



KUKU SABZI

PERSIAN APPETIZER

INGREDIENTS

5 tablespoons canola oil, divided
1 large yellow onion, finely chopped (about 1½ cups)
1 medium leek, finely chopped (about 1 cup)
Kosher salt, to taste
6 large eggs
2 teaspoons all-purpose flour
1 teaspoon baking powder
1 teaspoon kosher salt
1 teaspoon freshly ground black pepper
½ teaspoon ground turmeric
1½ cups very finely chopped flat-leaf parsley
1½ cups very finely chopped dill
1½ cups very finely chopped cilantro
1 tablespoon dried fenugreek (optional)
2 teaspoons dried rose petals, ground (optional)
Lavash bread, yogurt, fresh herbs and radishes, for serving

DIRECTIONS

1. Heat 2 tablespoons oil in a medium skillet over medium heat. Add the onions and leeks. Season with salt and cook, stirring occasionally, until very soft but not brown, 14 to 16 minutes. Remove from the heat and set aside to cool.
2. In a large mixing bowl, whisk together the eggs, flour, baking powder, salt, pepper and turmeric. Using a rubber spatula, stir in the herbs and cooled onion-leek mixture.
3. Position the rack on the upper third of the oven and turn on the broiler.
4. Heat the remaining 3 tablespoons oil in a 10-inch nonstick skillet over medium-low heat. Pour in the batter and spread evenly with a rubber spatula. Cook, covered, until the bottom has set, 10 to 12 minutes.
5. Place the skillet under the broiler, uncovered, watching carefully until the top has completely set, 1 to 2 minutes. Remove from the oven.
6. Slide the kuku sabzi onto a serving platter and garnish with the rose petals. Cut the kuku sabzi into wedges and serve with lavash bread, yogurt, fresh herbs and radishes.

Yield: 4 servings

Prep Time: 30 minutes

Cook Time: 30 minutes

Total Time: 1 hour



TAHCIN

PERSIAN BAKED RICE

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE FILLING:

3 tablespoons unsalted butter
 ½ medium yellow onion, minced
 1½ pounds boneless, skinless chicken thighs, cut into 1-inch pieces
 3 tablespoons lemon juice
 1 tablespoon salt
 2 teaspoons dried orange peel
 ½ cup plain whole yogurt
 1 egg

FOR THE RICE:

3 cups basmati rice, rinsed
 3 tablespoons kosher salt, divided
 1 stick unsalted butter, melted, divided

For the Topping:

1 cup dried barberries
 Parsley leaves, for garnish

DIRECTIONS

1. Up to 24 hours before serving, make the filling: In a medium skillet, melt the butter over medium heat. Add the onions and cook until translucent, 2 to 3 minutes. Add the chicken and cook, stirring occasionally until opaque, 10 minutes. Add the lemon juice and salt, and cook, partially covered, over medium-low heat until cooked, 10 minutes more. Remove from the heat and let cool.

2. Meanwhile, in a small saucepan, add the dried orange peel and cover with 2 inches of water. Bring to a boil and cook for 2 minutes, then drain. Return the peel to the saucepan and cover again with 2 inches of water. Bring to a boil, then remove from the heat and let sit for 5 minutes. Drain and mince.

3. In a medium bowl, mix the minced orange peel with the yogurt. Add the cooled chicken and marinate in the refrigerator for at least 3 hours and up to 24 hours.

4. Meanwhile, prepare the rice: Preheat the oven to 375°. Two hours before the chicken is finished marinating, place the rice in a large bowl with 2 tablespoons of the salt and cover with water. Let the rice soak for 2 hours, then drain.

5. Bring a large pot of water to a boil over high heat and season with the remaining tablespoon of salt. Add the rice and cook until tender, but still chewy, 5 minutes, then drain.

Yield: 8 to 10 servings

Prep Time: 30 minutes, plus cooling, marinating and soaking time

Cook Time: 2 hours

Total Time: 2 hours and 30 minutes, plus cooling, marinating and soaking time

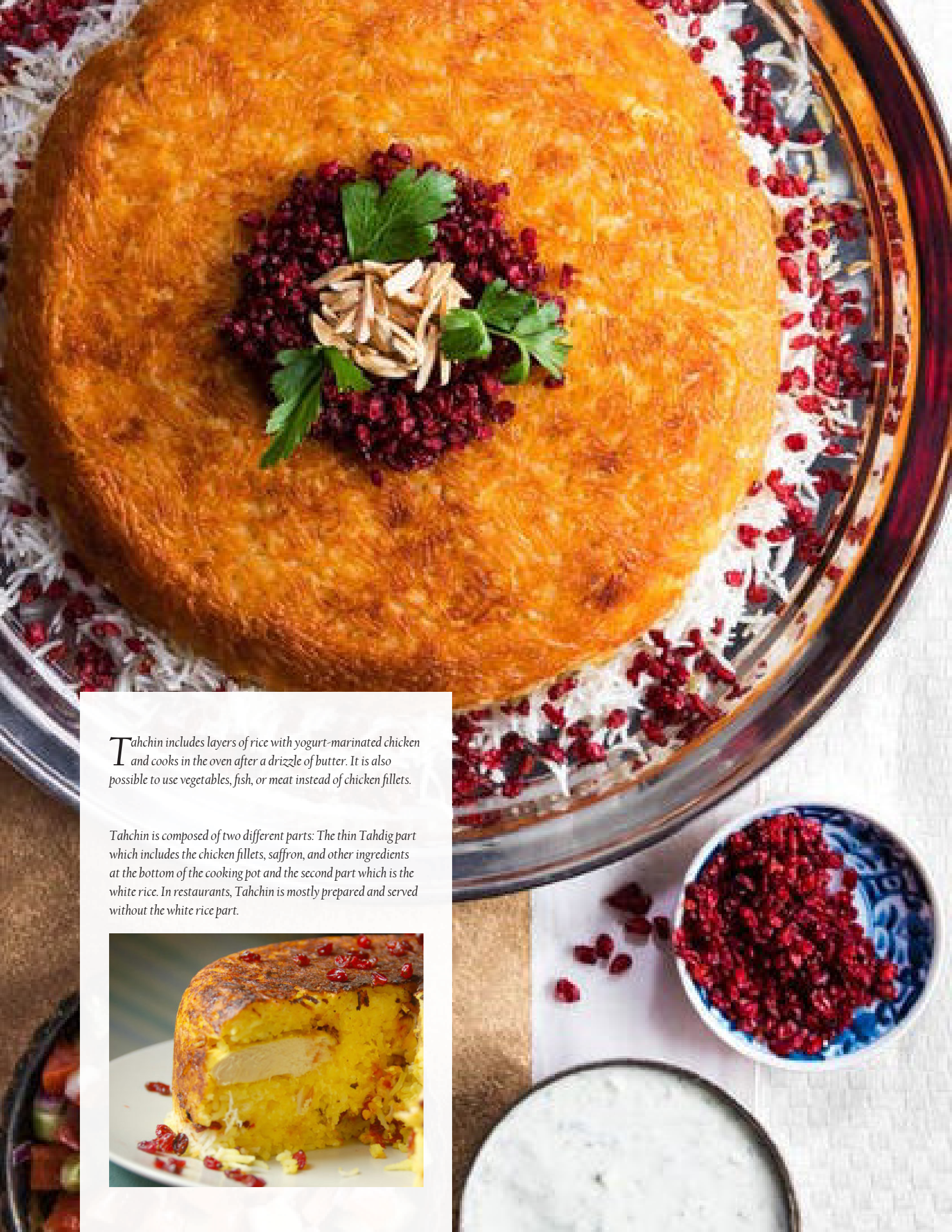


6. Meanwhile, strain the chicken mixture of its marinade and reserve the marinade liquid in a medium bowl. Whisk in the egg until smooth. Add 3 cups of the cooked basmati rice and stir to coat.

7. Grease a nonstick, ovenproof 12-inch pot with 2 tablespoons of the melted butter. Lay the marinade-coated rice on the bottom of the pot and press the rice up the sides of the pot by 1½ inches. Distribute the chicken pieces over the rice, leaving a 1-inch border, then top with the remaining cooked rice. Drizzle the remaining melted butter over the top layer of rice.

8. Cover the pot tightly with a lid or foil and bake the rice for 45 minutes. Reduce the heat to 350° and bake for 45 minutes more.

9. Fill your sink with 2 inches of cold water and place the pot into the water for 5 minutes; this will help the rice release from the sides of the pot. Remove from the sink and use a paring knife to separate the rice from the pot. Place a large plate or platter over the pot and invert the two so the tahchin falls onto the plate. Spoon the dried barberries on and around the tahchin, then garnish with parsley leaves and serve.



Tahchin includes layers of rice with yogurt-marinated chicken and cooks in the oven after a drizzle of butter. It is also possible to use vegetables, fish, or meat instead of chicken fillets.

Tahchin is composed of two different parts: The thin Tahdig part which includes the chicken fillets, saffron, and other ingredients at the bottom of the cooking pot and the second part which is the white rice. In restaurants, Tahchin is mostly prepared and served without the white rice part.



GHORMEH SABZI

PERSIAN HERB STEW

INGREDIENTS:

Sunflower oil
1 medium onion, finely chopped 4 garlic cloves, crushed
3 lb lamb shoulder, on the bone, trimmed, cut into 2-inch chunks
1 tsp turmeric
Sea salt and black pepper
About 2 cups cold water
1 large bunch parsley, finely chopped
1 large bunch cilantro, finely chopped
small bunch chives, finely chopped
3 cups spinach, trimmed and finely chopped
spring onions, finely chopped
15-oz can of red kidney beans, rinsed and drained
2 tbsp dried fenugreek leaf
6 dried limes
2 tbsp lemon juice

DIRECTIONS

1. Heat 2 tablespoons of sunflower oil in a large saucepan (one with a lid). Fry the onion for 10 minutes, until soft and light brown, then add the garlic and cook for 2 more minutes. Add the meat, turmeric, and ½ teaspoon of black pepper and brown the meat on all sides. Add enough cold water to cover the meat (around 2 cups), then put the lid on and cook on medium-low heat for 30 minutes.

2. Meanwhile, set aside 3 tablespoons parsley and 3 tablespoons cilantro and then place the rest of the herbs, the spinach, and the spring onions in a pan and dry-fry over low heat for 10 minutes to evaporate their water. Stir every so often so the herbs don't stick to the pan. Add 2 tablespoons of sunflower oil to your pan and fry the herbs for a further 10 minutes.

3. After the lamb has been cooking for 30 minutes, add the cooked greens, red kidney beans, fenugreek, and 1½ teaspoons of salt. Pierce the dried limes a few times with a fork and then add them too. Simmer, with the lid on, for 50 minutes. Stir through the lemon juice and the reserved parsley and cilantro. Press the dried limes against the side of the pot so they burst and then stir well to mix together.

Yield: 4 to 6 servings

Prep Time: 50 minutes

Cook Time: 2 hours and 30 minutes

Total Time: 3 hours and 15 minutes



4. Leave to cook for a final 10 minutes and then taste and adjust for seasoning, adding a bit more salt, pepper, or lemon juice, to taste. You can leave the limes in when serving, but you probably won't want to eat them, as they can be very bitter. While I like them, they are something of an acquired taste.



Gormeh Sabzi is an incredibly delicious Persian stew that is served over steamed rice and green salad. It has tender cooked meat in intensely fragrant, rich and lemon herb gravy along with kidney. Popularly known as the national dish of Iran, this stew is packed with protein and fibre.

For the best taste, make sure you get the meat on the bone; ask your butcher to cut it into small bite-size chunks and to trim off all the fat. And when you get home, give the lamb another look and trim off any remaining fat, as the dish can release a lot of oil. The number of herbs that need chopping might look a bit daunting but it shouldn't take more than 10 minutes to do and you can always stick them in a food processor—it won't affect the taste.





Faloodeh is an ancient Persian dessert, a sort of granita threaded with rice noodles and spiked with rose water and lime. Though you may typically cook noodles until al dente, you'll need to cook them through here before adding them to the syrup so that they soak up enough liquid to become as crunchy as possible as they freeze.

In Iran, most ice cream shops sell just two items: traditional saffron ice cream and faloodeh, which is typically topped with bottled lime juice that tastes mostly of citric acid. Faloodeh has been my favourite since childhood, but now I prefer it with the juice of freshly squeezed limes. It's incredibly refreshing and the ideal end to a rich meal filled with complex flavours.



FALOODEH

PERSIAN DESSERT

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE MACERATED STRAWBERRIES:

1 pound strawberries, hulled and cut into wedges
¼ cup fresh lime juice

FOR THE FALOODEH:

2 ounces rice vermicelli noodles
8½ cups water, divided
1¾ cups granulated sugar
1 tablespoon rose water

FOR ASSEMBLY:

Macerated strawberries
½ cup crushed unsalted, toasted pistachios
½ cup mint leaves, torn
1 tablespoon dried, ground rose petals (optional)
¼ cup to ½ cup fresh lime juice

DIRECTIONS

- 1.** Make the macerated strawberries: In a medium mixing bowl, combine all the ingredients and let them sit at room temperature for 30 minutes, tossing them occasionally until macerated. Strain the mixture and reserve ½ cup of liquid. Pour the remaining liquid back into a bowl with the strawberries and set it aside.
- 2.** Meanwhile, make the faloodeh: Place the vermicelli in a bowl. In a large saucepan over high heat, bring 6 cups of lightly salted water to a boil and pour the water over the rice vermicelli. Soak the noodles until they are tender, about 3 to 4 minutes. Drain and rinse the noodles with cold water. Using scissors, snip the noodles into 1- to 2-inch pieces; Set them aside.
- 3.** In a medium saucepan over medium-high heat, combine the remaining 2½ cups of water and sugar. Stir the mixture until the sugar dissolves, about 3 to 4 minutes. Remove the sugar from the heat and stir in the rose water. Pour the mixture into a nonreactive bowl along with the reserved ½ cup of macerated strawberry liquid, and chill it in the fridge for at least 2 hours.

Yield: 6 servings

Prep Time: 1 hour, plus 5 hours chilling time

Cook Time: 5 minutes

Total Time: 1 hour and 5 minutes, plus 5 hours chilling time



- 4.** Pour the chilled faloodeh base into a pre-chilled bowl of an ice cream machine and follow the manufacturer's instructions to churn until the mixture begins to turn icy around the edges, about 10 to 15 minutes. Add the rice noodles to the mixture, and continue to churn until the noodles begin to freeze and the mixture begins to look like slush, about another 10 to 15 minutes.
- 5.** Transfer it to an airtight container, and place plastic wrap directly onto the faloodeh. Chill it in the freezer for at least 3 hours before serving.
- 6.** To serve, scoop the faloodeh into a chilled glass or bowl, then top it with the macerated strawberries, pistachios, mint, rose petals (if using) and lime juice.

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